POLICY BRIEF

Disinformation: Treating the Problem at Its Root

A summary of the scientific evidence

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IN 1 MINUTE

Four findings

1. Disinformation is only the tip of the iceberg.
2. Its direct effects are overestimated, its indirect effects underestimated.
3. Embracing falsehood reflects social rationality, not a deficit of reason.
4. The heart of the problem is a crisis in the supply of quality information.

Four pillars for action

1. Drying up the supply of disinformation
2. Addressing the immediate causes of belief
3. Addressing the deep causes of belief
4. Supporting quality information

Executive summary

This brief offers a fresh diagnosis of disinformation, grounded in the cognitive and social sciences, and draws from it recommendations for French public policy.

Four findings frame the analysis:

- **Disinformation is only the tip of the iceberg.** Rare in actual use and concentrated among a small minority, it is above all the symptom of a broader crisis: a crisis of quality information (social media, the economic and trust crisis of legacy media) and, more deeply, a crisis of a society whose fractures make falsehood desirable.

- **Its direct effects are overestimated, its indirect effects underestimated.** No study reliably shows that online disinformation swings elections. But it can polarize, saturate, discredit, silence, and erode trust even in accurate information, and that is where the risk lies.

- **Embracing falsehood reflects social rationality, not a deficit of reason.** The public is more skeptical than gullible; people believe and share in order to belong, to signal loyalty, and to make sense of an experience of insecurity. Loneliness, perceived economic insecurity, and institutional distrust (often well-founded) are its roots.

- **The heart of the problem is a crisis in the supply of quality information.** Falsehood does not crowd out truth; rather, truth draws little attention, struggles to fund itself, and is losing its authority: those who produce it are no longer believed when they rule on what is true and what is false. Generative AI is worsening this dynamic: by answering questions directly, it captures media traffic and revenue.

Four pillars of recommendations follow:

PILLAR 1 — DRYING UP THE SUPPLY OF DISINFORMATION

Necessary but insufficient: go after what makes money and who spreads it, without ever making the state the judge of what is true.

1. Demonetize disinformation and synthetic engagement
2. Make platforms genuinely auditable, beyond self-reported transparency
3. Defend the authenticity of senders rather than the veracity of content
4. Regulate generative AI through its actors and their design choices

PILLAR 2 — ADDRESSING THE IMMEDIATE CAUSES OF BELIEF

The best-documented levers, but the most limited in reach; poorly calibrated, they teach people to doubt everything, including what is true.

5. Refocus media literacy on recognizing reliable information
6. Deploy prebunking in a targeted and repeated way
7. Entrust corrections to credible messengers rather than to the state
8. Use sharing frictions as frontline tools

PILLAR 3 — ADDRESSING THE DEEP CAUSES OF BELIEF

The most decisive lever and the hardest to pull: the welfare state (social protection, public services) is the strongest defense of the sovereign state (security, defense, public order).

9. Make public integrity a counter-disinformation policy
10. Reinvest in places of social connection to combat isolation
11. Reduce perceived economic insecurity and the non-take-up of benefits
12. Experiment with depolarization without overestimating its effects

PILLAR 4 — SUPPORTING QUALITY INFORMATION

Fighting for information is often more effective and less costly than fighting against disinformation.

13. Refinance local news on the model of Canada's *Local Journalism Initiative*
14. Guarantee stable funding and editorial independence for the media
15. Make AI contribute to the information it reuses
16. Equip intermediaries: fact-checkers, journalists, content creators

Cross-cutting condition: give ourselves the means to know (measure demand and not just supply, evaluate interventions, guarantee data access) and maintain restrained public communication.

IN A NUTSHELL

Fighting disinformation without addressing its causes is like bailing out a leaking ship: as long as public action is limited to visible responses against falsehood, it will leave intact the conditions that make falsehood effective, and risks deepening the very distrust it claims to fight.

INTRODUCTION

A different framing

In 2016, Oxford Dictionaries named *post-truth* its word of the year; in 2020, the World Health Organization declared an "infodemic"; the World Economic Forum then ranked disinformation among the top global risks two years in a row, and the first United Nations report on global risks placed it first among risks already unfolding.

In France, the fight against information manipulation became institutionalized within a few years: VIGINUM, the state agency that detects foreign digital interference, was created in 2021; the Quai d'Orsay (French foreign ministry) launched *French Response*, its unit that pushes back on social media, in 2025; and a National Strategy to Combat Information Manipulation was adopted in February 2026.

This mobilization is welcome, provided it is well aimed. Yet the dominant way of framing the problem rests on two partial representations. The first assumes a **passive and gullible public**, which could simply be corrected through fact-checking or media literacy. The second, **technocentric**, blames "post-truth" on social media and foreign interference, leaving in the shadows both the state of legacy media and the social, material, and identity-based roots of the phenomenon.

This framing does not merely distort the diagnosis; it warps public action. Policy favors immediate, visible responses (verifying, attributing, communicating) over

the slow work of strengthening the information ecosystem: **it puts out fires rather than making the ground less flammable.** Poorly calibrated, its instruments can even backfire. The most widespread ones do reduce belief in falsehood. But by constantly urging people to be wary, they also make the public more skeptical of accurate information (Hoes et al., 2024).

This brief proposes an alternative framing, in four steps. It first defines disinformation and measures its actual scale (Part 1). It then explains why people embrace and share it (Part 2), before situating its circulation within the information ecosystem as a whole (Part 3). Finally, it assesses counter-disinformation policies, organized into four pillars, in light of their effectiveness, their feasibility, and the state of the evidence (Part 4).

PART 1

Disinformation is only the tip of a deeper crisis

1.1. Disinformation, misinformation, malinformation: what are we talking about?

Research distinguishes three forms of "information disorder" according to two criteria, the falsity of the content and the intent to harm (Wardle and Derakhshan, 2017):

	FALSE CONTENT	TRUE CONTENT
Intent to harm	**Disinformation.** E.g., in 2017, a clone of the website of the Belgian daily *Le Soir* hosted a fake article about Saudi funding of Emmanuel Macron's campaign.	**Malinformation.** E.g., the "Macron Leaks," genuine emails released a few hours before the pre-election blackout period, when campaigning is closed and the targeted team can no longer respond, to cause maximum political damage.

	FALSE CONTENT	TRUE CONTENT
No intent to harm	**Misinformation.** E.g., during the Champs-Élysées attack (2017), internet users relayed in good faith the rumor that a second police officer had died.	*(ordinary information)*

In practice, these boundaries are blurry. The same message counts as disinformation when whoever spreads it knows it is false, and as misinformation when someone passes it on in good faith. Yet intent can rarely be proven. In French usage, including institutional usage, *désinformation* serves as an umbrella term; it is used here in that broad sense, without abandoning the analytical distinction.

> **ILLUSTRATION · MANIPULATING WITHOUT LYING**
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> *Imagine an outfit tasked with pushing for "Frexit", France's exit from the European Union, in a referendum. Using a platform's data (likes, follows), it identifies each user's interests and splits the audience into groups: this is micro-targeting. To animal-rights advocates, it shows only the European projects that make animal testing easier. To hunters, only the European proposals that restrict hunting. Every item is accurate.*
>
> *But each group sees only the fact selected to make it angry at Europe, without the rest of the picture or what the other groups are seeing. The two messages even pull in opposite directions (protecting animals on one side, defending hunting on the other), yet lead to the same conclusion: vote to leave. No lie is told, and yet the overall picture is distorted: it is selective framing, not falsehood, that manipulates. This is a textbook case of malinformation.*
>
> ***Take-away:** a policy that only hunts for "falsehood" is blind to this kind of operation, because there is no false content to flag or remove.*

Disinformation as a three-tier iceberg

Disinformation in the strict sense is only the visible part of a much larger whole. To understand it, it must be placed in two successive contexts: first the overall state of information (tier 2), then the society that receives it (tier 3).

TIER	WHAT IT CONTAINS	WHAT PUBLIC DEBATE SEES OF IT
1. The tip: disinformation	False content, interference campaigns, deepfakes, troll farms	Almost everything: this is what our instruments can measure and what the media cover
2. Below the surface: an information crisis	Misleading but accurate content, malinformation, low consumption of quality information, social media optimized for engagement, the economic and trust crisis of legacy media	Only part of it (social media), rarely the media crisis
3. The base: a social environment that fuels demand	Precarity, loneliness, polarization, institutional distrust (often well-founded)	Almost nothing: these causes fall under no agency responsible for disinformation

POSITION. A policy that addresses only the tip of the iceberg treats a symptom. Falsehood circulates because social demand makes it desirable (tier 3) and because a weakened ecosystem can no longer produce, disseminate, and lend credibility to the truth (tier 2). Tier 2 matters all the more because misleading but accurate content, as in the "Frexit" example above, escapes every measure based on falsity: nothing in it is false, so nothing gets counted. Added up, such content could nonetheless weigh more than falsehood itself (Allen, Watts and Rand, 2024, cited in Altay, 2026).

1.2. Overview of disinformation: rare, concentrated, with mostly indirect effects

Prevalence of disinformation: rare on screens, present in every mind

How much room does disinformation really take up? Published figures on its prevalence, that is, on how widespread it is, range from under 1% to a large majority. The most comprehensive systematic review to date, which pools all the available studies on the question (Altay, 2026: 443 studies, 1,048 estimates), makes it possible to settle this debate. These figures do not contradict one another: they do not measure the same thing, as the table below shows.

WHAT IS MEASURED	MEDIAN	HOW
Share of disinformation in what people consume online	**1.3%**	Browsing traces (18 studies)
Share of people exposed at least once	**12.0%**	Browsing traces (27 studies)
Share of disinformation in what people share	**13.0%**	Observed shares (45 studies)
Share of content classified as disinformation in a corpus	**23.0%**	Content analyses, often on a targeted topic (274 studies)
Share of people who *say* they have shared disinformation	**19.8%**	Surveys (36 studies)
Share of people who *say* they have seen disinformation	**57.7%**	Surveys (71 studies)

Measures of actual behavior yield the lowest figures, with among the highest levels of certainty; surveys, which measure perception, yield the highest; content analyses have the lowest level of certainty. In France, unreliable websites accounted for 0.16% of internet users' online time (Cordonier and Brest, 2021); in the United States, disinformation made up 0.15% of all the media people consumed, their "media diet"

(Allen et al., 2020), and more than 90% of Facebook users shared no content from a disinformation website during the 2016 campaign (Guess et al., 2019).

The gap between what is measured and what is perceived is not trivial: *perceived* prevalence predicts distrust of news, and media attention to disinformation can itself erode trust in reliable sources (Altay, 2026). In other words, believing that disinformation is everywhere in turn breeds distrust of all news. A problem measured at a few percent but experienced as massive therefore calls for policies calibrated on the measurement, not on the perception.

BOX 1 · HOW TO READ A FIGURE ON DISINFORMATION

Every prevalence figure is a ratio: what was counted as disinformation, divided by the whole it is compared with. The same fake news articles represented 1% of Americans' news consumption, but 0.15% of their total media consumption (Allen et al., 2020): what is counted stays the same; only the reference total (the denominator) changes. Three questions are enough to avoid most misreadings:

- ***A percentage of what?*** *Of time spent online, of shares, of the content in a corpus, of people? A "million views" means nothing until you know out of how many views in total: it is not a prevalence.*
- ***How was the corpus built?*** *A sample of vaccine videos, or of the most-viewed content, describes that corpus, not everyone's environment.*
- ***What was counted as false?*** *In content analyses, counting only fabricated content gives a median of 3.5%; adding false content, 21.5%; adding misleading content, 27.0%.*

Overall, differences between studies stem mainly from how each one identifies disinformation: this choice of method explains about one fifth of the differences in results, compared with only 1.8% for the topic studied (health, politics, etc.). Finally, actual exposure on video platforms and messaging apps (YouTube, TikTok, WhatsApp, Telegram) remains largely unknown, for lack of data (Altay, 2026).

AN OPEN SCIENTIFIC DEBATE

The role of disinformation remains contested in research, but the disagreement is narrower than it looks. Altay and Mercier see it first as a symptom of deeper problems, such as polarization or distrust. They grant that it shapes the specific form false beliefs take, but consider its causal effect on behaviors such as vaccine refusal unproven (Altay and Mercier, 2026).

Ecker and colleagues reply that it is both a symptom and a cause: effects that are modest for each individual can weigh heavily at the scale of a society, and the problems it worsens in turn feed belief (Ecker et al., 2024; Ecker et al., 2025; Tay et al., 2026).

Where there is consensus. *Both sides acknowledge that there is a demand for disinformation and that it has deep causes, such as distrust or polarization. Ecker and colleagues do not dispute that disinformation is a symptom; they add that it is also a cause.*

What remains uncertain. *The specific effect of supply is unclear: no strong evidence shows that it alone changes beliefs, votes or behaviors at scale. Absence of evidence is not evidence of absence, however. Slow, cumulative or indirect effects, spread over years, largely escape current study designs, and ethics forbids deliberately exposing people to false content over long periods.*

Pasquetto, Lim, and Bradshaw show that the polarization of this debate harms the field itself (Pasquetto et al., 2024). *This brief therefore puts its main effort on demand, where agreement is broad, while keeping proportionate action on supply, whose effects cannot be ruled out.*

Uneven exposure to disinformation: an average that hides what matters

An average of 1% does not mean that everyone sees 1% falsehood. When a billionaire walks into a room, the average income of those present soars, although nobody else has become richer: an average says nothing about distribution. **Disinformation is extremely concentrated, in its consumption as well as in its production and dissemination**: the vast majority see almost none of it, while a small minority see and share an enormous amount.

- **Concentration of exposure and sharing.** The most active 1% of users account for a median of **70%** of disinformation-related activity (visits, exposures, shares),

compared with **30 to 43%** for news in general (Altay, 2026). On Twitter in 2016, **1% of users accounted for 80% of exposures** to disinformation and **0.1% were responsible for 80% of shares** (Grinberg et al., 2019).

- **Concentration of sources.** On Twitter in the United States, 5% of *fake news* sources produced more than half of all exposures; in Germany, the three most-visited unreliable domains captured about half of all visits to such sites (Grinberg et al., 2019; Altay, 2026).
- **Social and political concentration.** These are mostly older, highly politicized users and, in the United States, right-leaning ones: people over 65 shared nearly seven times as many misleading links as 18- to 29-year-olds (Guess et al., 2019); when a study compares the two camps, the right-leaning group is, at the median, 3.7 times more exposed or active than the left-leaning group (Altay, 2026). Only a fringe on the far right had feeds dominated by unreliable content (Grinberg et al., 2019).

What this changes. Disinformation behaves less like diffuse pollution affecting the whole population than like the activity of a small, highly motivated minority that actively seeks it out. Policies designed for "the whole population" therefore largely target people who are barely exposed to it, while those most exposed are also the hardest to reach.

Effects of disinformation: unproven direct effects, more worrying indirect effects

Two types of effects must be distinguished; it is confusing them that distorts the debate.

Direct effects (making people believe a specific fact, changing a vote or a behavior): very weak level of evidence.

- A systematic review concludes that no problematic behavior has been "reliably empirically demonstrated to result from disinformation" (Adams et al., 2023).
- Mass persuasion is difficult in general: the average effect of campaign contact (canvassing, calls, mail) and political advertising on voting in US general elections is estimated at zero across 49 field experiments (Kalla and Broockman,

2018); removing all political advertising on Facebook and Instagram during the six weeks before the 2020 presidential election had no measurable effect (Allcott et al., 2026).

- The Russian *Internet Research Agency*'s Twitter campaign in 2016 potentially reached 32 million Americans, but 1% of users accounted for 70% of exposures to this content, and they were nearly all partisans whose minds were already made up. No link appears between exposure and changes in attitudes or voting (Eady et al., 2023).
- The most cited experimental findings measure intentions, not behaviors: exposure to anti-vaccine messages reduces stated intention to get vaccinated by about 6 points (Loomba et al., 2021), but the actual decision depends on many other factors, starting with trust in one's doctor.
- Part of our fear stems from a bias: we judge others to be far more easily influenced than ourselves, the so-called "third-person effect" (Altay and Acerbi, 2024).

Indirect effects: a more modest but real level of evidence, and the most worrying. Disinformation does not need to make people believe a specific fact in order to do harm.

- **Polarizing and dividing.** The IRA simultaneously ran fake *Black Lives Matter* accounts and ultraconservative pages to stoke tensions. The link with polarization and eroding trust is documented, but is more correlational than causal (Tucker et al., 2018).
- **Saturating and confusing.** The Russian "firehose of falsehood" doctrine consists of pouring out, continuously and across many channels, a stream of numerous and sometimes contradictory messages. The aim is less to convince than to disorient: faced with so many claims, checking them becomes too costly and the public no longer knows what to believe (Paul and Matthews, 2016).
- **Discrediting and silencing.** Coordinated harassment of journalists, such as Maria Ressa in the Philippines, or *deepnudes* targeting women politicians, raise the cost of speaking out.

- **Shifting perceived norms rather than beliefs.** Propaganda can act as a signal rather than as an argument. Under Nazism, antisemitic propaganda broadcast on the radio converted few people. But it let already convinced antisemites know that violence would no longer be punished (Adena et al., 2015).
- **Offering a "liar's dividend."** The more everyone knows that content can be fabricated, the easier it becomes to dismiss authentic evidence as "AI-generated." A liar caught out thus draws a benefit (a "dividend") from the mere existence of fakes. The effectiveness of this maneuver depends mainly on the public's prior distrust (Schiff et al., 2025).
- **Eroding trust in what is true.** This is the most worrying effect, because it is also produced by the fight itself: alarmist discourse lends credence to the idea that elections can be manipulated at will (Jungherr and Rauchfleisch, 2024), and the most widespread interventions increase skepticism toward accurate information (Hoes et al., 2024).

> **CORE RISK · DEFENDING WITHOUT SELF-HARM**
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> Take a candidate genuinely targeted by a disinformation campaign, but whose result was barely affected. If they lose, they may seize on it to contest their defeat. They are right to say they were targeted, but wrong to make it the cause of their loss. The manipulation then does harm less through its effect on voters than through the use subsequently made of it: casting doubt on a legitimate election. **Take-away:** overstating the threat is not neutral, because it hands arguments to those who want to delegitimize a result.

BOX 2 · WHAT ABOUT GENERATIVE AI? DEFLATIONARY ABOUT THE PAST, VIGILANT ABOUT THE FUTURE

The upheaval predicted for the 2024–2025 elections did not happen. In India, about 1% of the viral WhatsApp messages analyzed contained AI-generated content (Garimella and Chauchard, 2024)*; Meta reports that less than 1% of fact-checked disinformation was AI-generated; in the United Kingdom, only 16 viral cases were recorded in 2024, and 11 for the European and French elections combined, with no demonstrated effect on the results* (Stockwell et al., 2024)*.*

Crude edits (cheapfakes) dominated. A sophisticated fake is not needed: what attracts the public is the story being told, not the technical quality of the doctoring. And people believe content mainly according to who passes it on, far more than how it looks.

These figures describe the situation at a given moment; nothing guarantees that AI will remain this little used. Two areas call for vigilance. First, ***persuasion through dialogue****: in a reasoned conversation, AI convinces as well as or better than human debaters* (Salvi et al., 2025)*.*

Second, ***indirect effects*** *on the ecosystem: the liar's dividend, declining trust, contamination of the texts AI models learn from (the pro-Russian "Pravda" network duplicated its content across some 150 websites, presumably so that models would absorb and repeat it), and above all the capture of media traffic and revenue (see Part 3). Finally, AI is a pharmakon, a Greek word meaning both poison and remedy: it can also be used to fight disinformation. For instance, a dialogue with an AI reduces conspiracy belief by about 20%, an effect that persists after two months* (Costello, Pennycook and Rand, 2024)*.*

PART 2

People embrace falsehoods not out of credulity, but for social reasons

2.1. Why people embrace disinformation: from the naive model of credulity to social rationality

Most policies rest on an implicit model of human psychology: exposure to falsehoods supposedly produces beliefs mechanically, which in turn produce

behaviors. Correcting errors would therefore be enough to eliminate their effects. The evidence contradicts every link in this chain.

The public is more skeptical than credulous. The most comprehensive meta-analysis (67 studies, 40 countries, more than 190,000 participants) shows that people rate true news as markedly more accurate than false news. Their dominant error is the opposite of the one we fear: they **reject true information more often than they accept false information** (Pfänder and Altay, 2025). Yet a decision based on rejecting an established fact is just as harmful as one based on a falsehood: restoring trust in accurate information matters as much as stemming falsehoods.

When people get it wrong, it is first and foremost through inattention. People who take less time to think things through, relying more on first impressions, find false news more credible, regardless of their political orientation (Pennycook and Rand, 2018, two studies, more than 3,000 participants). At the moment of sharing, attention rarely turns to accuracy: people pass on surprising or moving content without asking themselves whether it is true.

When identity is at stake, reasoning is put in the service of the group. Distrust is not randomly distributed: it targets information that runs counter to one's own side and spares information that bolsters it. This is the "partisan brain" (Van Bavel and Pereira, 2018) and "identity-protective cognition" (Kahan, 2017). A counterintuitive result: as affective polarization rises, that is, hostility toward the other side beyond mere disagreement over ideas, credulity toward narratives favorable to one's own side rises too.

This effect peaks **among the most educated**: they use their reasoning skills to justify whatever suits their side, rather than to correct their mistakes (Jenke, 2024). Identity does not, however, abolish sensitivity to truth: on average, people find a true but unfavorable news item more credible than a false but favorable one (Pfänder and Altay, 2025).

Sharing is not believing. Passing on a rumor about an opponent's corruption can be a way of taking a stand and rallying one's own side, regardless of its truth. The

more outlandish a belief, the more effectively it can signal loyalty to the group: defending it costs credibility with outsiders, and it is precisely this cost that proves commitment.

Conversely, many people refrain from sharing falsehoods because doing so damages their reputation (Altay, Hacquin and Mercier, 2022). Spreading false information can therefore be **socially rational**: rationality is not failing; it is being put in the service of social and identity-related ends.

Believing is not acting. The literature refers to a "belief-action gap": accepting an idea entails neither the commitment nor the sacrifice it would demand. If believing were enough to act, the climate crisis would have been overcome long ago.

> **EXAMPLE · VACCINE HESITANCY**
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> *During the pandemic, many French people voiced reservations about the Covid-19 vaccine. Yet many of them got vaccinated. Their stated distrust therefore did not dictate their behavior: it was sometimes less a conviction than a way of expressing protest.* ***Take-away:*** *what people say they believe does not always predict what they do.*

> **IMPORTANT NUANCE · NO COMPOSITE SKETCH**
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> *There is no typical profile of the person vulnerable to disinformation. Links with age, education, or personality are weak, and they change depending on what is measured. Vulnerability instead follows a "U"-shaped curve: low at the center, it rises the further one moves away from it, on the right as on the left* (Krouwel et al., 2017). *What matters, then, is less being on the right or the left than holding radical positions. Finally, even if personality played a role, it would not be a legitimate lever: public action has no business targeting citizens according to their psychological traits.*

These mechanisms are amplified in polarized societies. Polarization reinforces motivated reasoning, pushes people toward like-minded media, and turns adherence to a favorable narrative into a proof of loyalty (Tucker et al., 2018). And polarization is growing: in the French National Assembly, the semantic distance

between political groups, that is, the gap between the words they use, **increased sixfold between 2007 and 2024** (Algan et al., 2025).

In the United States, the affective gap between partisans of the two camps (the difference between how warmly they feel toward their own side and toward the other, on a 0-to-100 scale) rose from **27 to 56 points** over forty years (Boxell et al., 2024).

> **POSITION.** Correcting factual errors is not enough: we must act on the conditions that make these narratives socially functional.

2.2. The deep roots of the demand for disinformation

Disinformation does not thrive in a social vacuum: it **meets a demand**. When inequality deepens and the ties that bind people to a group (work, family, associations) come apart, shared bearings fade. Misleading narratives then fill the gap: they offer simple explanations, designate culprits, and restore a sense of belonging to a group.

Precariousness, isolation, distrust, and polarization thus form a **grammar of insecurity**: a single lived experience of insecurity, expressed in several forms. This experience does not mechanically turn individuals into receptacles for falsehoods. But it makes certain narratives more plausible and leaves fewer resources to challenge them.

Perceived precariousness. It is not so much objective poverty as perceived precariousness (fear of the future, a sense of exclusion, a feeling of abandonment) that fuels conspiracism, in France and Italy (Adam-Troian et al., 2023, more than 3,000 respondents), a finding confirmed in 17 European countries (Adamus et al., 2024, more than 50,000 participants in total).

At the societal level, conspiracy thinking is more common where unemployment and inequality are higher (Cevik, 2024, 27 countries), and perceiving one's society as

unequal increases adherence to conspiracy narratives, via the feeling that society is falling apart (Casara, Suitner and Jetten, 2022). **Precariousness does not make people credulous; it makes them distrustful, and that distrust opens the door to disinformation.**

Loneliness. In Norway, 2,215 people were followed from 1992 to 2020: loneliness in adolescence, as well as its worsening, predicts conspiracy belief in adulthood, independently of social background, political orientation, and anxious or depressive symptoms (Bierwiaczonek et al., 2024).

These beliefs recast isolation as proof of lucidity, steer people toward homogeneous communities that validate them, and offer a substitute sense of belonging. And France is becoming more isolated: **12% of French people were relationally isolated in 2024, compared with 9% in 2010**; 24% often feel lonely, rising to 35% among young adults and 44% among jobseekers (Fondation de France, 2025).

Institutional distrust, often well founded. When institutions are perceived as corrupt, their denials lose credibility and conspiracy narratives gain plausibility: when people distrust an institution, they require less proof to believe that it is lying or plotting.

After the Ebola epidemic in Liberia, citizens who perceived the state as corrupt were more inclined to accuse it of having caused the disease (Maffioli and Gonzalez, 2022); among African American patients, past medical racism has fostered lasting distrust and strong vaccine hesitancy (Bogart et al., 2021). This distrust is not an error by irrational citizens: it generally tracks actual levels of corruption (OECD, 2022).

BOX 3 · THE CRISIS OF TRUST IN FRANCE

- *At most one in five French people trust the government (**17%**), the president (18%), or the National Assembly (20%); mayors and municipal councils garner around **60%*** (CEVIPOF, the Sciences Po political research center, 2026).
- *82% consider democracy a good system in principle, but **76%** believe it works poorly* (CEVIPOF, 2026).
- *In 2025, France reached its **historic low** on Transparency International's Corruption Perceptions Index (66/100, ranked 27th), below the average for full democracies (71).*
- *Trust in scientists remains high (**82%**), one of the strongest bulwarks against health disinformation.*

These data point less to a rejection of the democratic ideal than to a discrediting of its concrete institutions.

POSITION. Distrust is to a large extent a proportionate reaction to institutions' real failings. No communication campaign will therefore reduce it: only tangible action can. Fighting disinformation without addressing these vulnerabilities is like bailing out a ship without plugging its leaks.

PART 3

The information ecosystem: falsehood is not displacing truth; truth is weakening

Better to fight for information than against disinformation. The simulations by Acerbi, Altay and Mercier (2022) show this: in an environment where reliable information is far more abundant than falsehood, **reducing acceptance of all disinformation to zero would improve the overall state of beliefs as much as, but no more than, increasing acceptance of reliable information by a single percentage point.** Why?

Because falsehood is only a small fraction of what people see: even if nobody believed it any more, few beliefs would be corrected. Reliable information, by contrast, makes up most of what they see: persuading slightly more people to trust it therefore improves a very large number of beliefs at once. The room for improvement therefore lies with the broad reliable base, not the thin misleading fringe.

Yet it is precisely this base that is eroding. News occupies a minimal place in everyday use: in France, news sources account for only **3% of time spent online, less than five minutes a day**; **17%** of the people tracked consulted none at all over thirty days, 46% spent less than an hour on them in total, and visits to any given source rarely last more than two minutes (Cordonier and Brest, 2021).

In the United States, 86% of media time involves no form of news whatsoever (Allen et al., 2020). The problem is not that falsehoods fill our screens; it is that **verified information struggles to attract interest**, and that those who produce it struggle to make a living from it.

3.1. Social media and disinformation: non-neutral infrastructures, but not all-powerful ones

Gateways that have become major, especially among young people. Social media and video platforms are the main source of news for **19%** of French people, compared with 34% of Americans, and for 44% of 18-24-year-olds compared with 15% of those aged 55 and over. Six platforms now exceed 10% weekly use for news, compared with two a decade ago (Newman et al., 2025). The public identifies them as the leading vectors of disinformation, with Facebook (49%) and TikTok (48%) at the top.

Architectures that favor the salient over the reliable. Platforms do not manufacture falsehoods; they shape how they circulate. Their recommender systems, optimized for engagement, advantage negative, conflictual, and emotional content (Chavalarias et al., 2024). Disinformation thrives there because it is a "cognitive attractor", that is, content tailored to capture our attention: it plays on threat,

disgust, moral transgression, or sexuality, with just enough surprise to intrigue without seeming absurd (Acerbi, 2019).

It is not its falsity that makes it go viral, but properties that true content can possess just as well. Finally, a small, highly active, and unrepresentative minority produces most of the content, which makes online norms appear more extreme than they are (Barberá et al., 2015). Algorithms are not neutral: on X, the algorithmic feed favors conservative content and activist accounts, demotes news outlets, and shifts certain political attitudes (Gauthier et al., 2026).

But the effect of algorithms is more limited than commonly believed.

- *Echo chambers are rare.* Measured across people's entire media diet, they concern roughly **6 to 8%** of the public in the United Kingdom; most people maintain diverse sources (Ross Arguedas et al., 2022).
- *Our own choices matter at least as much.* On Facebook, the algorithm's ranking reduces exposure to content from the opposing political camp by about 5 to 8%. Our own choices of what to click reduce it further, by 6 to 17% (Bakshy et al., 2015).
- *Changing the algorithm does not mechanically change opinions.* Switching to a chronological feed on Facebook in 2020 actually slightly **increased** the share of unreliable sources (from 2.6% to 4.4%), with no effect on polarization (Guess et al., 2023).
- *The most cited study needs qualifying.* The finding that "falsehood spreads six times faster than truth" (Vosoughi et al., 2018) concerns rumors that had already been contested and fact-checked, not information in general; during the pandemic, fact-checks and scientific information sometimes spread faster than falsehoods.

BOX 4 · SOCIAL MEDIA AS PHARMAKON

Deactivating Facebook for four weeks increases well-being and slightly reduces polarization, but ***lowers levels of political knowledge*** (Allcott et al., 2020)*; the same finding emerged in France during the 2022 presidential election* (Arceneaux et al., 2024).

Conversely, asking French and German participants to follow news media accounts on Instagram and WhatsApp for two weeks ***increases their knowledge, their discernment, and their trust in the media*** (Altay et al., 2025)*. Like a pharmakon (Greek for both poison and remedy), social media harm or help depending on dose and use. The challenge is therefore not to flee social media, but to control the dosage and give quality information a real presence there.*

The new layer: AI. Recommender systems, which choose what appears in our feeds, are a form of AI that has been in operation for a decade. They are the AI-related risk backed by the most solid evidence. They are also what decides whether AI-generated content will be seen by a handful of people or by millions.

Conversational assistants, for their part, insert themselves between the public and information by substituting a single answer for a list of sources; their errors on electoral questions are documented, but their use for news remains modest: in 2025, 7% of respondents used them weekly to get news (Newman et al., 2025). Their most serious effect lies elsewhere: the crowding out of quality information (see 3.2).

POSITION. Platforms must be regulated through their design choices and economic incentives. But blaming technology alone spares us from looking at the fractures it amplifies and at the weakening of the media that should act as a counterweight.

3.2. The crisis of traditional media: the bulwark against disinformation is weakening

Media that are still central. In France, the rise of platforms has not erased established media: **72%** of French people get their news every day from television,

49% from the press, and 35% from radio, compared with 45% from social media, influencers, or AI tools (La Croix-Verian, 2026).

They also remain the most credible: TV news (**65%**), the regional press (**63%**), and the national press (58%), far ahead of online-only sites (40%), AI (28%), social media (27%), and influencers (20%). And they still produce most of the news, even online: around 40% of time spent on news on the Internet is concentrated on traditional media, led by the regional press (Cordonier and Brest, 2021).

But a threefold crisis is weakening them.

1. **An economic crisis.** The share of advertising revenue going to media that produce content fell from **65% in 2012 to 40% in 2022** (DGMIC-Arcom, 2024); only **11%** of French people pay for online news (Newman et al., 2025); the abolition of the public broadcasting license fee in 2022 weakened public service media. Under this constraint, newsrooms favor commentary and debate, which are cheaper, at the expense of investigation and reporting.
2. **A crisis of trust.** Only **29%** of French people trust "most news," compared with 38% in 2015 (41st out of 48); **61%** believe that "one should be wary" of what the media say (Newman et al., 2025; La Croix-Verian, 2026).
3. **A crisis of independence.** The growing concentration of ownership, highlighted by the French Senate in 2022, fuels suspicions of interference; only 42% of French people consider the regional press independent of political pressure.
Why this fuels disinformation. Distrust of the media increases the credibility granted to misleading news (Zimmermann and Kohring, 2020). French people who have consulted a disinformation source are not less interested in the news: they are more interested in it, but trust the media and institutions less (Cordonier and Brest, 2021).

Above all, the local press plays an irreplaceable civic role: the arrival of a first newspaper in a town increases voter turnout by about 0.3 points (Gentzkow, Shapiro and Sinkinson, 2011); the closure of a local daily increases polarization and reliance on national partisan cues (Darr, Hitt and Dunaway, 2018). **The decline of local journalism does not create falsehoods; it depletes the institutions capable of producing, prioritizing, and lending credibility to the truth.**

AI is worsening the crisis through disintermediation. The term means that the public no longer needs to go through the outlet that produced the information: AI summarizes it for them directly. AI-generated answers at the top of search engines thus establish a "zero-click" logic: users obtain information without visiting the site that produced it. Yet that site depended on that visit for its revenue.

- The drop in click-through rates when an AI summary is present is estimated at between **35% and 60%** depending on the study (Pew, Ahrefs, Seer Interactive, 2025; methods disputed by Google).
- Google traffic to 2,500 news sites fell by **33%** in one year; small publishers lost around **60%** of their search traffic in two years; AI assistants combined send **less than 1%** of visits to publishers' sites (Chartbeat, 2026).
- **60%** of reliable news sites prevent AI companies' crawlers from collecting their articles, compared with **9%** of disinformation sites (Steinacker-Olsztyn et al., 2025). Models, which learn from what they collect, therefore risk drawing more on falsehood than on truth.

These industry data are of lower quality than academic studies, but their convergence is hard to dismiss. A vicious circle sets in: by capturing the value of information without funding its production, AI is drying up the very source on which the quality of its own answers depends.

> **POSITION.** Refinancing the media is not an ancillary cultural policy: **it is a counter-disinformation policy in its own right.**

PART 4

Countermeasures against disinformation: effective levers exist, but they are the least visible

Background: a public response to disinformation that has gained momentum, but is poorly targeted

A dense arsenal. France has long-standing legislation penalizing certain uses of falsehood (the 1881 press law, the electoral code, the penal code), to which a 2018 law added an emergency electoral injunction against false information: a fast-track procedure allowing anyone to ask a judge, during an election period, to have false information swiftly removed. It was used only once, in 2019, and the court dismissed the claim. The center of gravity has since shifted to Europe. The EU's *Digital Services Act* (DSA), in force since February 2024, requires very large platforms to assess and mitigate their "systemic risks", that is, the harm their operation can cause at the scale of society, disinformation included.

The Code of Practice on Disinformation, a set of commitments made by the platforms, has been integrated into it: since July 2025, compliance with it can be checked through audits; the *AI Act* (2024) regulates manipulation and the transparency of synthetic content. The National Strategy of February 2026 organizes fifteen objectives into four pillars (mobilizing the nation, regulating platforms and AI, strengthening operational capacity against interference, acting with allies); VIGINUM, the agency for countering foreign digital interference, detects and documents such operations, while *French Response* pushes back on social media.

A security-driven, exogenous framing. Exogenous means here that the threat is seen as coming from outside (foreign states, platforms) rather than from society itself. For the first time, this strategy acknowledges that disinformation exploits societal vulnerabilities. But it treats them as external context and favors technical, educational, and legal responses that can be deployed immediately. The same framing dominates in Europe: in 238 speeches by European Commission leaders (2016–2024), disinformation is attributed primarily to hostile states and platforms, through military and medical metaphors (Fattorini et al., 2025).

This framing pays off politically: publicly attributing an interference operation to a state or debunking a piece of content produces visible, immediate action for which officials can claim credit, whereas tackling root causes would be slow and invisible. It also obscures domestic spreaders, even though citizens rank their own politicians (47%) ahead of foreign governments (39%) among the producers of disinformation (Newman et al., 2025).

A practitioners' diagnosis focused on supply. A survey of more than one hundred French counter-disinformation professionals (military officers, senior civil servants, regulators, journalists) sheds light on these biases (Darcy and Altay, 2026):

- **90%** name platforms as a major threat, while only **18%** name ordinary citizens;
- **88%** get their information in French, whereas the reference literature is in English, and barely a third keep up to date;
- **76%** consider the gap between rhetoric, which makes disinformation a priority, and the resources actually deployed to be very or extremely problematic;
- **63%** say they are held back by fear of being accused of censorship, whereas only **21%** say they often face genuine ethical dilemmas (62% rarely or never): it is fear of the accusation, more than scruples, that holds them back;
- Half regret the lack of a lead agency: each ministry handles "its own" disinformation;
- **96%** expect interference to intensify, but only **one in eight** believe the state's resources will be up to the task.

A measurement problem. A successful resilience policy, by its very nature, produces no visible effect: its success is a manipulation that fails to take hold, and no one sees what does not happen. Unable to measure effects, institutions count what is easy to count: campaigns detected and content removed, that is, supply. Yet what gets measured shapes what gets done: action concentrates on responding, and the technology-centered diagnosis is reinforced.

A democratic safeguard. Worldwide, 80 countries adopted or amended a law targeting online disinformation between 2010 and 2022, 75 of them after 2016, most

often through penalties and content removal (Bradshaw et al., 2025). Giving the government, or judges ruling in emergency proceedings, broad power to determine what is true would create a truth police.

It would feed the censorship narrative, and thus the distrust that is the breeding ground of the problem. **In defending itself, democracy must not confiscate the right to challenge the referees**: citizens must remain free to question those who say what is true, the state included.

The levers are presented below in four pillars. For each, expected effectiveness follows the assessment grid drawn up in 2026 from the scientific literature by the DITP (the French government's inter-ministerial directorate for public transformation) and VIGINUM (●●●● very high, ●●●○ high, ●●○○ moderate, ●○○○ limited); an asterisk marks the author's own estimate. "Deployability" indicates how easy a lever is to implement (cost, political and technical feasibility); "evidence", how solid the available studies are.

PILLAR 1

Drying up the supply of disinformation

Necessary but insufficient: it acts on the tip of the iceberg. It must target the money disinformation brings in and the authenticity of those who spread it, never the truth of content, which is not for the state to decide.

1 Demonetize disinformation and synthetic engagement

Effectiveness ●●○○

Cutting off advertising revenue to disinformation sites, fake-account networks, and automated content farms means tackling the economic incentive rather than individual pieces of content one by one. "Synthetic engagement" means likes, shares, and comments produced artificially (fake accounts, bots) to simulate popularity. The Code of Practice makes demonetization an auditable commitment. We must go further and **decouple remuneration from engagement**: as long as platforms pay for content according to the reactions it generates, manufacturing fake reactions remains profitable.

> *Limitations: the platforms themselves capture part of this revenue and have a conflict of interest in drying it up; some political elites have little interest in seeing the measure succeed.*

2 Make platforms genuinely auditable

Effectiveness ●○○○

The DSA mandates transparency, risk assessment, and researcher access to data. But it remains compliance-based regulation, which mainly checks that procedures are followed: platforms assess their own risks and propose their own remedies, and oversight depends on the data they provide (Toledano, 2026; Wolters and Zuiderveen Borgesius, 2025).

What is needed is **genuine auditability** of recommender systems and advertising spending: being able to trace every change to the algorithm, measure what goes into it and what comes out, and give independent experts direct access. In the longer term, recommendation itself must also be pluralized: letting everyone choose, on the same platform, a ranking algorithm designed by a third party (interoperability, *middleware*), along the lines of projects such as Tournesol.

> *Limitations: the specific effect of algorithmic changes on disinformation is poorly established; a chronological feed is no panacea* (Guess et al., 2023). *Moreover, platforms are already retreating: in January 2025, Meta ended its third-party fact-checking program.*

3 Defend the authenticity of senders rather than the veracity of content

Effectiveness ●●○○*

The race to detect fakes is lost from the outset, because fakes keep getting better. It is better to reverse the logic and **guarantee the provenance of authentic content**, for instance through C2PA-type provenance standards: a kind of certificate attached to a photo or video that shows who produced it and whether it has been altered.

As for campaigns, it is better to spot them by their **coordination signals** (accounts posting at the same time, recycled accounts, shared infrastructure) than by their content. This is how VIGINUM characterized "Doppelgänger" (fake websites imitating real news outlets) and "Portal Kombat" (a network of pro-Russian propaganda sites).

> *Non-negotiable safeguards: voluntary certification, preserved pseudonymity, and no presumption of falsehood for content without a certificate of origin. Otherwise whistleblowers and witnesses, who often need to remain anonymous, would be put at risk. False positives also carry a high democratic cost: wrongly labeling a spontaneous grassroots mobilization as a coordinated operation delegitimizes real citizens.*

4 Regulate generative AI through the actors behind it

AI is not an impersonal force: companies, billionaires, and states make design and deployment choices. Regulation should cover: **transparency** (knowing that one is talking to an AI) and a ban on covert persuasion; **template responses**: on voting procedures, assistants would point users to official sources rather than answer themselves; **civic accuracy audits**, which test before each election how accurately AI systems answer electoral questions; **auditable training corpora**, to check that the texts AI learns from have not been contaminated; limits on *sycophancy*, that is, the tendency of AI companions to always agree with their user, a heightened risk for isolated users; and **specific criminal protection** against *deepnudes* targeting female candidates. These accountability requirements also apply to the state and to campaign teams when they use AI.

PILLAR 2

Addressing the immediate causes of belief

The best-documented, least costly, and easiest levers to deploy. But their reach is limited, and when poorly calibrated, they fuel skepticism toward all information, true and false alike.

The immediate causes of belief play out at the moment people encounter a piece of information: the attention they pay to it, their verification reflexes, their ability to recognize a reliable source. The levers of this pillar strengthen this individual resilience.

5 Refocus media literacy on recognizing reliable information

Effectiveness ●●○○ · Deployability high · Evidence strong

According to a meta-analysis of 33 studies, media literacy has the largest average effect among training interventions (Lu et al., 2024). In India, a fourteen-week program for 13,500 pupils improved discernment, with effects lasting four months and extending to parents, at a cost of less than $5 per pupil (Amar et al., 2025). In France, CLEMI, the national center for media and information literacy, is the main provider.

> *Weaknesses: training focused on hunting down falsehoods can foster distrust of all media* (Bateman and Jackson, 2024). *The positive side must therefore be taught: recognizing quality information. Only 22% of respondents to the Digital News Report, the Reuters Institute's annual international survey, say they have received such training (17% among older people, who are nonetheless the main spreaders), and France lags well behind.*

6 Deploy prebunking in a targeted and repeated way

Effectiveness ●●○○ · Evidence strong

Prebunking, or "inoculation," works like a vaccine: people are exposed, in small doses and in advance, to manipulation techniques (fake experts, false dilemmas, emotional appeals), so that they can recognize them when they encounter them. According to a meta-analysis of 42 studies, this reduces the credibility of misleading content and improves discernment (Lu et al., 2023).

It is the most robust countermeasure against AI-generated disinformation, because it teaches people to spot techniques, whatever the content. It should be targeted at predictable attacks during election periods: voice cloning, false information about voting procedures.

> *Limitations: effects erode without boosters (Maertens et al., 2021); on X, a campaign reaching 967,640 users produced no measurable change in sharing, as a large share of them had probably never seen the video (Roozenbeek et al., 2025).*

7 Entrust correction to credible messengers rather than the state

Effectiveness ●○○○ · Deployability high · Evidence strong

Fact-checking improves the accuracy of beliefs but does little to shift attitudes and behavior (Porter and Wood, 2024). Its main problem is reach: **almost no readers of an unreliable article read the corresponding fact-check** (Guess, Nyhan and Reifler, 2020), and on Facebook, two-thirds of interactions with corrections come from users already on the "science" side (Zollo et al., 2017). In a country where institutional trust is low, a denial issued by the state is likely to be less effective than a correction delivered by newsrooms or civil society organizations.

> *Limitations: to be fully effective, fact-checking would need to identify all disinformation, correct it in time, and reach those who saw it, three conditions that are out of reach. A public, moralizing denial can also reinforce those who see themselves as "anti-establishment."*

8 Use sharing frictions as frontline tools

Effectiveness ●○○○ · Evidence strong

A "friction" is a small hurdle placed before sharing to prompt reflection. Since falsehoods are often shared through inattention, prompting people to judge the accuracy of a headline before sharing it improves the quality of the links they share (Pennycook et al., 2021), an effect observed in 16 countries among 34,286 participants (Arechar et al., 2023).

> *Limitations: effects are modest and fragile; poorly calibrated friction slows all circulation, including that of reliable information in emergencies. In 2020, Twitter abandoned an extra click before retweeting for this reason.*

EMERGING TOOL · AI AS A REMEDY

A dialogue with an AI that offers personalized, evidence-based counterarguments reduces conspiracy belief by about 20%, an effect that persists after two months (Costello, Pennycook and Rand, 2024). *These uses deserve support under three conditions: transparency (users know they are talking to an AI), voluntary participation (never undeclared state persuasion), and independent evaluation, since an AI optimized to persuade tends to lose accuracy* (Hackenburg et al., 2025).

PILLAR 2 ASSESSMENT

These interventions improve discernment, but they rarely reach the most exposed audiences first, and they act more on judgments than on behavior. They reduce belief in falsehoods but can erode trust in what is true (Hoes et al., 2024): their net effect must be evaluated, not assumed. This first safety net is necessary but falls far short.

PILLAR 3

Addressing the deep causes of belief

The most structural lever, and the hardest to pull. Against disinformation, the welfare state (social protection, public services, social ties) is the strongest defense of the sovereign state (security, defense, public order): it reduces the vulnerabilities that manipulation exploits.

The deep causes of belief are the social conditions that make falsehood appealing: distrust of institutions, perceived economic insecurity, isolation, and polarization (Part 2.2). The levers of this pillar act on them.

9 Make public integrity a counter-disinformation policy

Effectiveness ●●●○ · Deployability high · Evidence moderate

Since distrust is a proportionate reaction to real failings, it recedes not through communication but through action: genuine probity among officials, real sanctions for misconduct, quality public services, justified decisions. The OECD (2022) proposes five operational dimensions: reliability, responsiveness, integrity, openness, fairness.

> *Limitations: restoring trust requires precisely what distrust prevents, namely credible reforms and citizens willing to believe in them long enough to see their effects. Yet since 2021, ministers under formal investigation have stayed in office, such as Justice Minister Éric Dupond-Moretti, or have been appointed, such as Rachida Dati as Culture Minister in 2024.*

10 Reinvest in places of social interaction to counter isolation

Effectiveness ●●●○ · Deployability moderate · Evidence weak

Associations, libraries, media libraries, community centers, "third places": these spaces for meeting and for the everyday exchange of viewpoints reduce isolation, one of the most consistent predictors of conspiracy belief. Many have disappeared.

11 Reduce perceived economic insecurity and the non-take-up of benefits

Effectiveness ●●●○ · Deployability very limited · Evidence weak

Access to housing, employment, health care, mental health services, and local public services; transition funds and medical and social support in declining areas.

> *Feasibility obstacle: at the end of 2025, public debt stood at 117% of GDP; public services have been deteriorating for three decades (Vezinat, 2024); above all, the people most vulnerable to disinformation are those whom public action no longer reaches, with non-take-up, that is, not receiving a benefit one is entitled to, affecting between a third and more than half of eligible recipients depending on the benefit (Warin, 2016). Informational resilience policies run up against the same "last mile" as social policies: the hardest part is not designing the help, but getting it to the people concerned.*

12 Experiment with depolarization without overestimating its effects

Effectiveness ●○○○*

Organized contact between opposing camps, citizen deliberation (*Braver Angels* workshops, Irish citizens' assemblies), and the correction of metaperceptions, that is, informing each camp of the other's actual positions, which are often less extreme than imagined, produce measurable effects.

> *Limitations: across 77 interventions, these effects are very modest and fade in less than two weeks (Holliday et al., 2025), and the interventions mostly recruit people already open to dialogue. Structural levers (elite behavior, electoral systems, media pluralism) are more promising but less tested.*

FUNDAMENTAL OBSTACLE

These levers exceed the mandate of the administrations in charge of disinformation (intelligence, armed forces, diplomacy, the regulator), none of which controls any of them. The ministries that do hold them (social affairs, culture, education) must be brought into the governance of this policy.

PILLAR 4

Supporting quality information

The most effective pillar according to the DITP-VIGINUM grid, and the most neglected. Since the problem is first and foremost a growing scarcity of quality information, supporting it acts more directly than correcting falsehoods after the fact.

13 Restore funding for the local press

Effectiveness ●●●● · Deployability moderate · Evidence moderate

The regional daily press is trusted by 63% of French people; 73% believe it highlights the most important news. Canada shows what an ambitious policy can achieve: the *Local Journalism Initiative* has mobilized **C$128.8 million since 2019**, funding more than **400 journalist positions** covering nearly **1,500 underserved communities**, with funds administered by nonprofit organizations to keep the state at arm's length from editorial decisions, and content shared under an open license.

Two objections. "Subsidizing the press would fuel suspicion of state-controlled media": the architecture of the funding answers this (independent funds, financing positions rather than editorial lines, full transparency), and the alternative, journalism dependent on platforms and AI, would be worse for independence. "The fringe that seeks out falsehoods will not read the local press": this is true, but they are not the target; local news makes the ground less flammable for the general public. *Cost: in the United States, an ambitious revival has been estimated at between $10 billion and $52 billion per year* (Bateman and Jackson, 2024).

14 Guarantee stable funding and editorial independence

Effectiveness ●●●● · Deployability limited · Evidence moderate

A newsroom right of approval, allowing journalists to accept or reject a new owner in the event of a change of control; transparency of shareholding; joint governance, in which journalists and shareholders share decisions; and stable public funding for public service media kept at arm's length from editorial decisions (Cagé and Huet, 2021; European Media Freedom Act, 2024).

15 Make AI contribute to the information it reuses

Effectiveness ●●○○*

Organize value sharing between AI providers and publishers, building on neighboring rights, which already require platforms to pay the press for reusing its content; require assistants to cite and link to sources; extend to AI providers the researcher access to data provided for in Article 40 of the DSA, currently limited to very large platforms and search engines. Nothing currently organizes this value sharing.

16 Equip the messengers: fact-checkers, journalists, creators

Effectiveness ●●●○ · Deployability high · Evidence weak

A growing share of information circulates through content creators, who act as de facto intermediaries: **62%** do not systematically check their sources, **73%** would like to learn how, and **42%** take "likes" as a sign of credibility (UNESCO, 2024). Public authorities should equip these messengers (training, databases, detection tools, transfer of research findings) rather than do the correcting themselves.

Summary table: prioritizing the levers against disinformation

PILLAR	INTERVENTION	BRIEF LEVER	EFFECTIVENESS	DEPLOYABILITY	LEVEL OF EVIDENCE
4 · Quality information	Support and revitalize the regional daily press	13	Very high	Moderate	Moderate
	Ensure stable funding for the media and guarantee their independence	14	Very high	Limited	Moderate
	Support other content producers	16	High	Very high	Weak
	Support and equip the fact-checking sector	16	High	High	Weak
3 · Deep causes	Strengthen public integrity	9	High	High	Moderate
	Reinvest in spaces of social interaction	10	High	Moderate	Weak
	Strengthen social, economic, and public health policies	11	High	Very limited	Weak
2 · Immediate causes	Media and information literacy	5	Moderate	High	Strong
	Inoculation (prebunking)	6	Moderate	Moderate	Strong

PILLAR	INTERVENTION	BRIEF LEVER	EFFECTIVENESS	DEPLOYABILITY	LEVEL OF EVIDENCE
	Fact-checking	7	Limited	High	Strong
	Display the source of information and its reliability	8	Limited	Moderate	Strong
	Introduce a reflective pause	8	Limited	Limited	Strong
	Display the source to equip the reader	8	Very limited	Limited	Strong
1 · Supply	Clean up the digital space and promote reliable information	1, 3	Moderate	Moderate	Moderate
	Modify recommendation algorithms	2	Limited	Very limited	Moderate

Adapted from the DITP-VIGINUM (2026) grid, to which the author contributed, and from Table 1 of La Désinformation (Darcy, 2026). *Deployability incorporates implementation costs and the ease of political or technical deployment. The grouping by pillar is specific to this brief.*

> **THE PARADOX TO OWN UP TO**
>
> The best-documented interventions (fact-checking, inoculation, nudges, i.e. small prompts such as sharing frictions) are those with the most modest effects; the levers deemed most decisive (local press, media independence, public integrity, social cohesion) are the most costly, the slowest, and the hardest to evaluate. They take fifteen or twenty years to produce their effects, whereas a term of office lasts five. That is precisely why they are neglected, and why they must be brought back to the forefront.

Cross-cutting condition · Equipping ourselves to measure disinformation and evaluate policies

- **Measure demand, not just supply**: regularly survey the same sample of people (a panel) on their exposure to disinformation, their beliefs, their trust, and their isolation. This tracking would be entrusted to a trusted body such as INSEE, the national statistics institute, under statistical confidentiality, and carried out at the same pace as the tally of foreign campaigns.
- **Evaluate the programs** already funded, through randomized or quasi-experimental trials, as well as the net effect of interventions on trust in what is true.
- **Guarantee researcher access to data** from platforms and AI providers (Article 40 of the DSA).
- **Make research accessible to practitioners**: syntheses in French, and a team tasked with turning research findings into operational guidance.
- **Keep public communication sober**: alarmist rhetoric has a measurable cost to trust.

CONCLUSION

Disinformation is not a war to be won, but a balance to be restored

Disinformation is neither a marginal accident nor an all-powerful instrument of manipulation. Rare on our screens and concentrated among a small minority, it has few demonstrated direct effects; but it takes hold because it latches onto very real vulnerabilities that are worsening in France: polarization, loneliness, economic insecurity, institutional distrust, and the economic weakening of the media. If policy remains unchanged, the trajectory is toward a society more permeable to misleading narratives, and practitioners themselves expect the deterioration to continue.

Breaking out of this trajectory requires acting simultaneously on all four pillars:

DRYING UP THE SUPPLY OF DISINFORMATION

Dry up economic incentives and guarantee the authenticity of senders, without ever instituting a truth police.

ADDRESSING THE IMMEDIATE CAUSES OF BELIEF

Calibrate interventions so that people learn to recognize what is reliable rather than to doubt everything.

ADDRESSING THE DEEP CAUSES OF BELIEF

Address the roots of demand: public integrity, social ties, material security. Here, the welfare state (solidarity, public services) and the sovereign state (security, defense) are complementary.

SUPPORTING QUALITY INFORMATION

Restore funding for, and protect, those who produce, verify, and lend credibility to the truth, starting with the local press.

These pillars are inseparable: without social justice, distrust will continue to feed receptiveness to falsehoods; without strong, independent media, critical education will have nothing reliable to point people toward; without an understanding of the real drivers of belief, regulation and education will miss their target.

Between panic, which itself lends credence to the idea that elections can be manipulated at will, and complacency, the only defensible position is one of **evidence-based vigilance**: staying alert to the threat, but relying on measurement and evaluation rather than on impressions. It entails societal choices that science can inform but not settle: the degree of solidarity a community is willing to fund, the integrity it demands of its leaders, the place it reserves for a free press. A democracy must be able to respond to manipulation; it must never do so at the cost of the right to challenge its referees.

AT A GLANCE

Key figures

INDICATOR	VALUE	SOURCE
Share of disinformation in what people consume online (median, behavioral measures)	**1.3%**	Altay, 2026 (18 studies)
Share of French internet users' online time spent on unreliable websites	**0.16%**	Cordonier and Brest, 2021
Share of people exposed at least once (behavioral measures)	**12%**	Altay, 2026 (27 studies)
Share of people who *say* they have seen disinformation (surveys)	**57.7%**	Altay, 2026 (71 studies)
Share of disinformation-related activity (visits, shares) attributable to the most active 1% of users	**70%** (median)	Altay, 2026
Same indicator for news in general	**30 to 43%**	Altay, 2026
Share of online time devoted to news in France	**3%**, less than 5 min/day	Cordonier and Brest, 2021
Gain in the accuracy of beliefs if nobody accepted any disinformation at all (simulation)	The same gain as **+1 point** in acceptance of reliable information	Acerbi, Altay and Mercier, 2022
Readers of an unreliable article who also read the corresponding fact-check	**Almost none**	Guess, Nyhan and Reifler, 2020
French trust in "most news most of the time"	**29%** (38% in 2015), 41st out of 48	Reuters Institute, 2025
Share of advertising revenue going to content-producing media	**40%** in 2022 (65% in 2012)	DGMIC-Arcom, 2024

INDICATOR	VALUE	SOURCE
French people experiencing relational isolation	**12%** in 2024 (9% in 2010)	Fondation de France, 2025
French counter-disinformation professionals who see a major threat in platforms / in ordinary citizens	**90% / 18%**	Darcy and Altay, 2026

Bibliography and recommended reading

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